

The deceiving demon

To arrive at his famous '*Cogito, ergo sum*', Descartes devised a thought experiment to narrow down the things we can be certain of. Suppose, he suggested, that there is an evil and powerful demon deceiving me about everything I think I know. Every belief I have is then thrown into doubt, as it could be the demon making me believe it. The only belief left to me that I can be certain of is my own existence, since the demon could not be deceiving me if I did not exist. This thought experiment is similar to the idea of the 'flying man' (see [Avicenna and the flying man](#)), deprived of information from all his physical senses, which led Avicenna to similar dualist conclusions. There are several modern versions of the 'deceiving demon' concept, most famously the scenario that an evil scientist keeps my brain in a vat of nutrients and electrically stimulates it so that I experience physical sensations that give me an illusory sense of reality. More recently, this has been elaborated (notably in the film *The Matrix*) to the suggestion that the world as we know it is a virtual one, a computer simulation we have been wired into.

